School Desegregation Policies in Barcelona: A Realist Evaluation Approach

Preliminary findings | Please do not cite.

GEPS
Globalisation, Education & Social Policies

Desegpol
School desegregation policies in the city of Barcelona

UAB
Universitat Autònoma de Barcelona

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1. Introduction: general background

- Growing international interest in reducing school segregation indexes (Dupriez et al., 2023)
- Adoption of reforms with moderate or null effects (Cummings et al., 2023; Grenet et al., 2021)
  - Regulation of student admissions: quotas
  - Covering schooling costs
- Few evaluations, mostly focusing on aggregate impacts, which neglect mechanisms-based explanations.
- **Research gap:** explanatory studies focusing on how and why desegregation policies work or fail.

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2. Context: Barcelona's education market

Catalonia & Barcelona: sustained policy omission in the field of school segregation (Bonal, 2012)**:**

- **High levels of school segregation** (BCN ≠ Catalonia)
  - 0.41-0,52 dissimilarity index (2013-2024)

- **High percentage of enrolment in private subsidised schools**: 50.3% in pre-primary and primary education, and 59.2% in secondary education.
  - **Add-on tuition fees** in private subsidised schools (Gortazar, Martínez & Bonal, 2024)

- **Controlled school choice system** for public and private subsidised schools (catchment areas, quotas, centralised admission system), **but high families' capacity of choice** (Bonal et al., 2021):
  - **Minimum guarantee:** 12 schools
  - **Average:** 18.5 schools.

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2. Context: SP (2019)

- **Targeted population**: primary and secondary education students of low socioeconomic status = vulnerable students
- **Main goal**: avoid the concentration of students in risk of vulnerability in specific schools and enhance equality of opportunities for those students in risk
- **Strategy:** promote an even distribution of vulnerable students using 3 different policy instruments:

1. Improvement and increased detection of 'social vulnerability'
2. Quotas for vulnerable students proportional to the social vulnerability in the catchment area
3. Schooling cost coverage for vulnerable students

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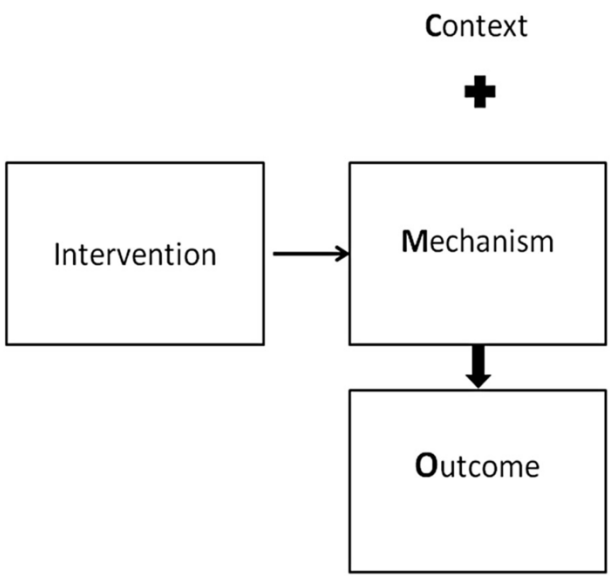
3. Goals & research questions

- Analyse how and why the SP succeeds (or not) in reducing school segregation.
  - Explore how the different SP instruments modify the behaviour of education agents (families, schools, social services)
  - Analyze how contextual elements affect these behavioral changes.

4. Analytical approach: Theories ofChange & Realist Evaluation

- Evaluate implicit or explicit theories of change of given program/policy (Pawson, 2006)

- The 'heuristic' tools of RE: Intervention, Context, Mechanisms, Results (De Weger et al., 2020; Lemire et al., 2015; Greenhalgh y Manzano, 2022)



→ CANVIAR GRAFIQUITO

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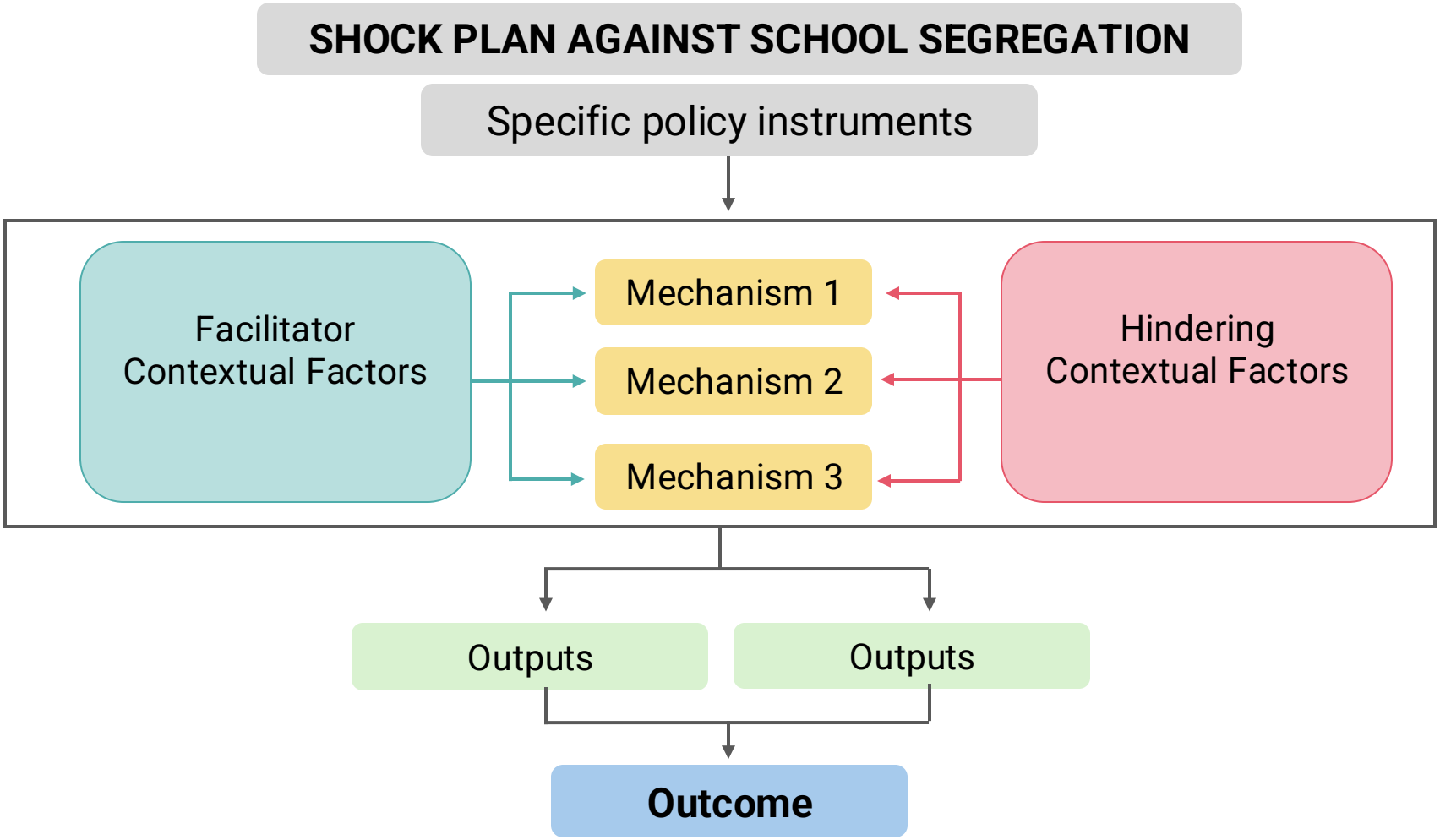
5. Data & instruments

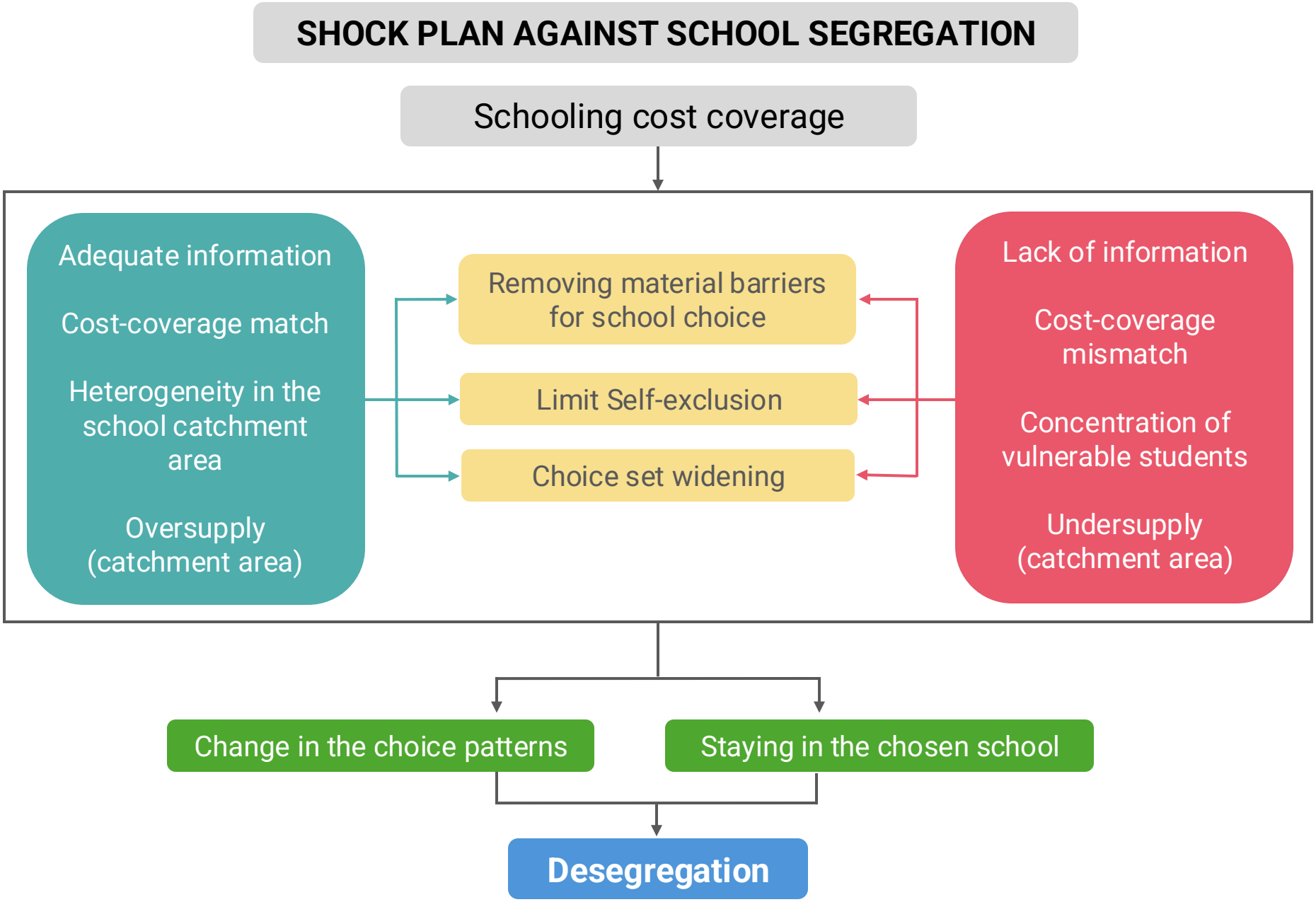
- **Mixed-method approach**
  - Questionnaire with principals (80)
  - Administrative data at the school and district level (social composition, school demand and supply, demographics, etc.)
  - Interviews with policymakers and mid-range bureaucrats (8), principals (32) and families (67)

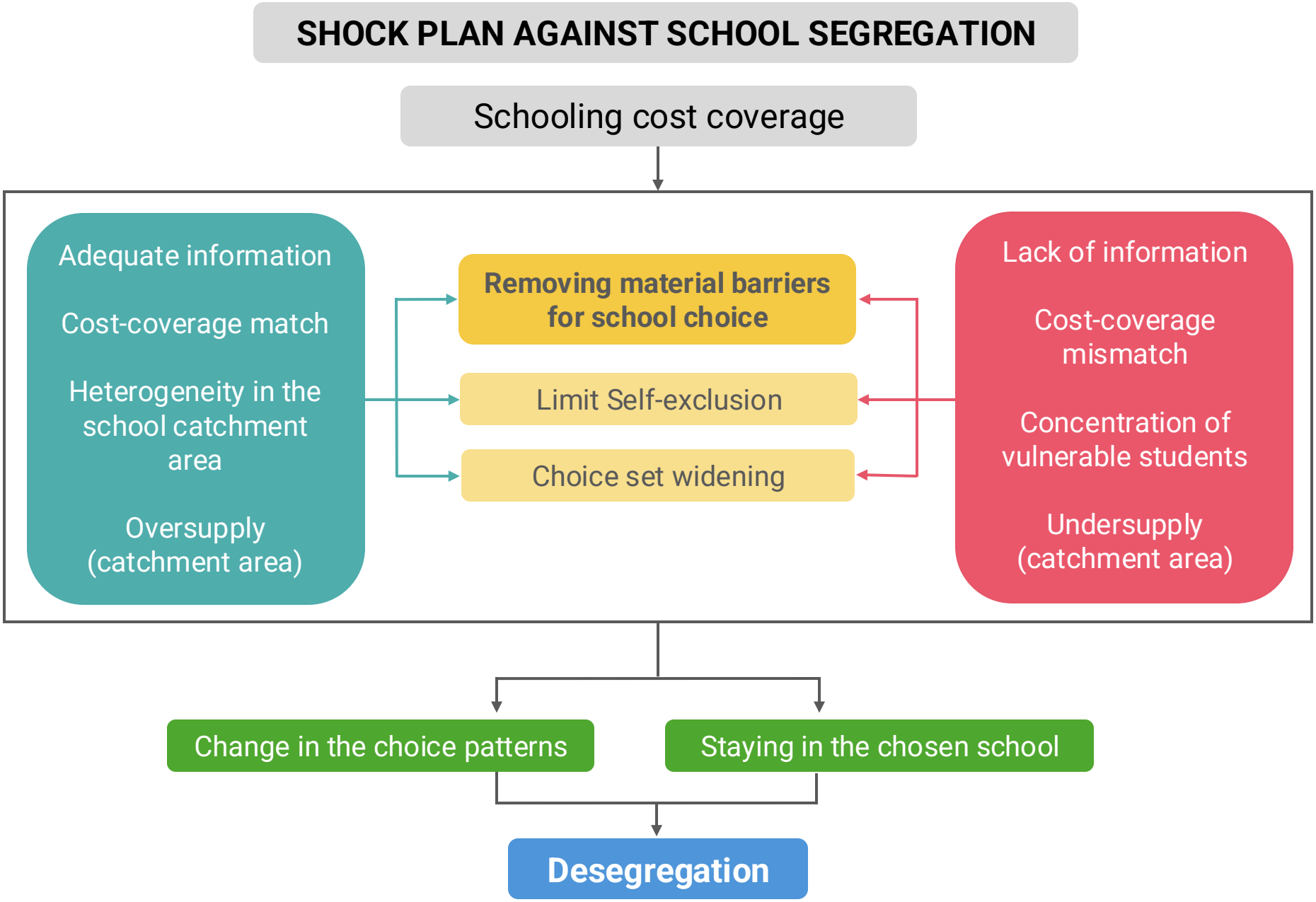
All the data is aimed at the reconstruction of the causal chain of the program (theory-driven evaluation)

- What is expected to happen and how?
- What actually happen and why?

6. Main results: Program causal chain (model)




SHOCK PLAN AGAINST SCHOOL SEGREGATION
Schooling cost coverage
Adequate information
Cost-coverage match
Heterogeneity in the school catchment area
Oversupply (catchment area)
Removing material barriers for school choice
Limit Self-exclusion
Choice set widening
Lack of information
Cost-coverage mismatch
Concentration of vulnerable students
Undersupply (catchment area)
Change in the choice patterns
Staying in the chosen school
Desegregation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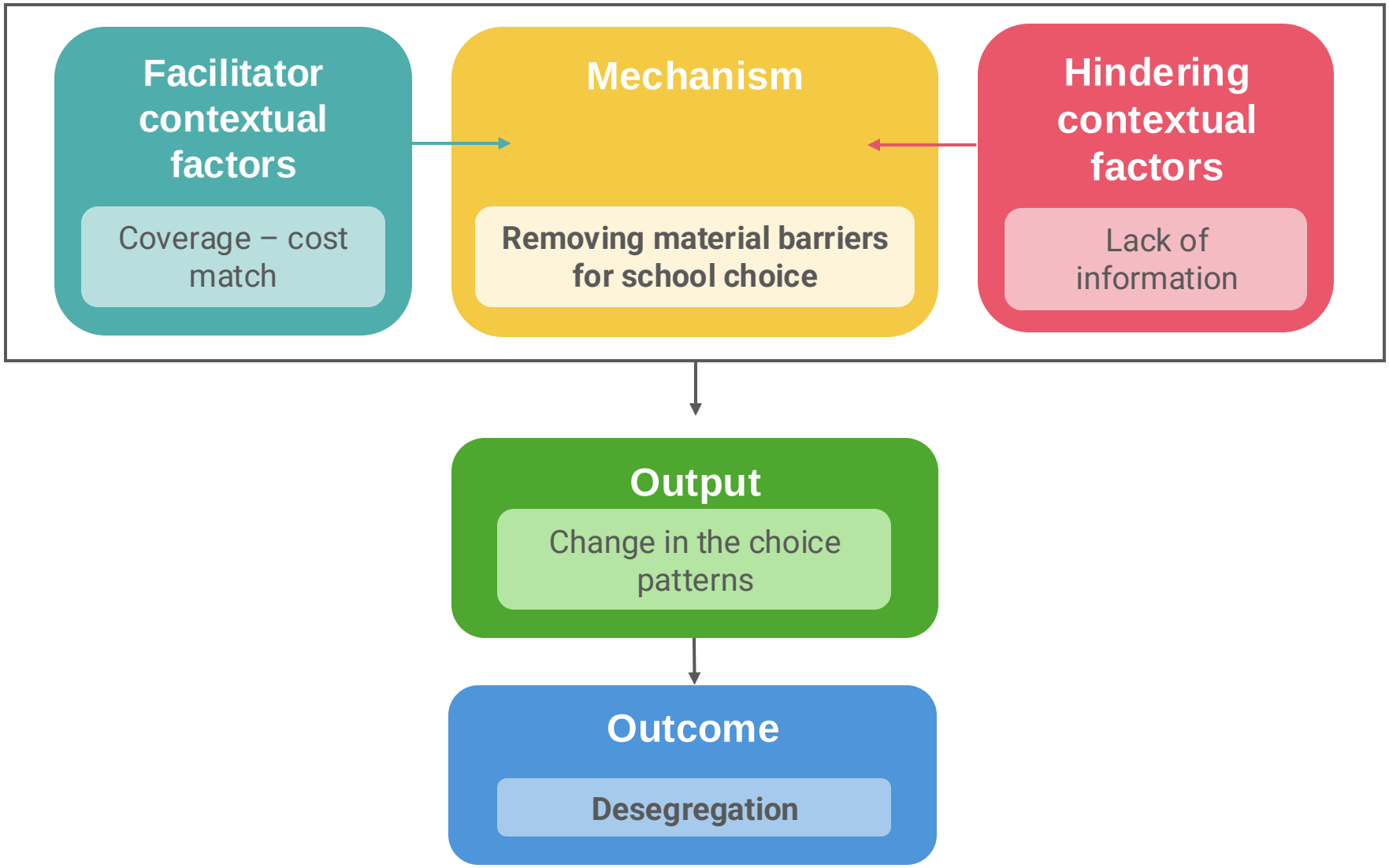
Mechanisms: exemple



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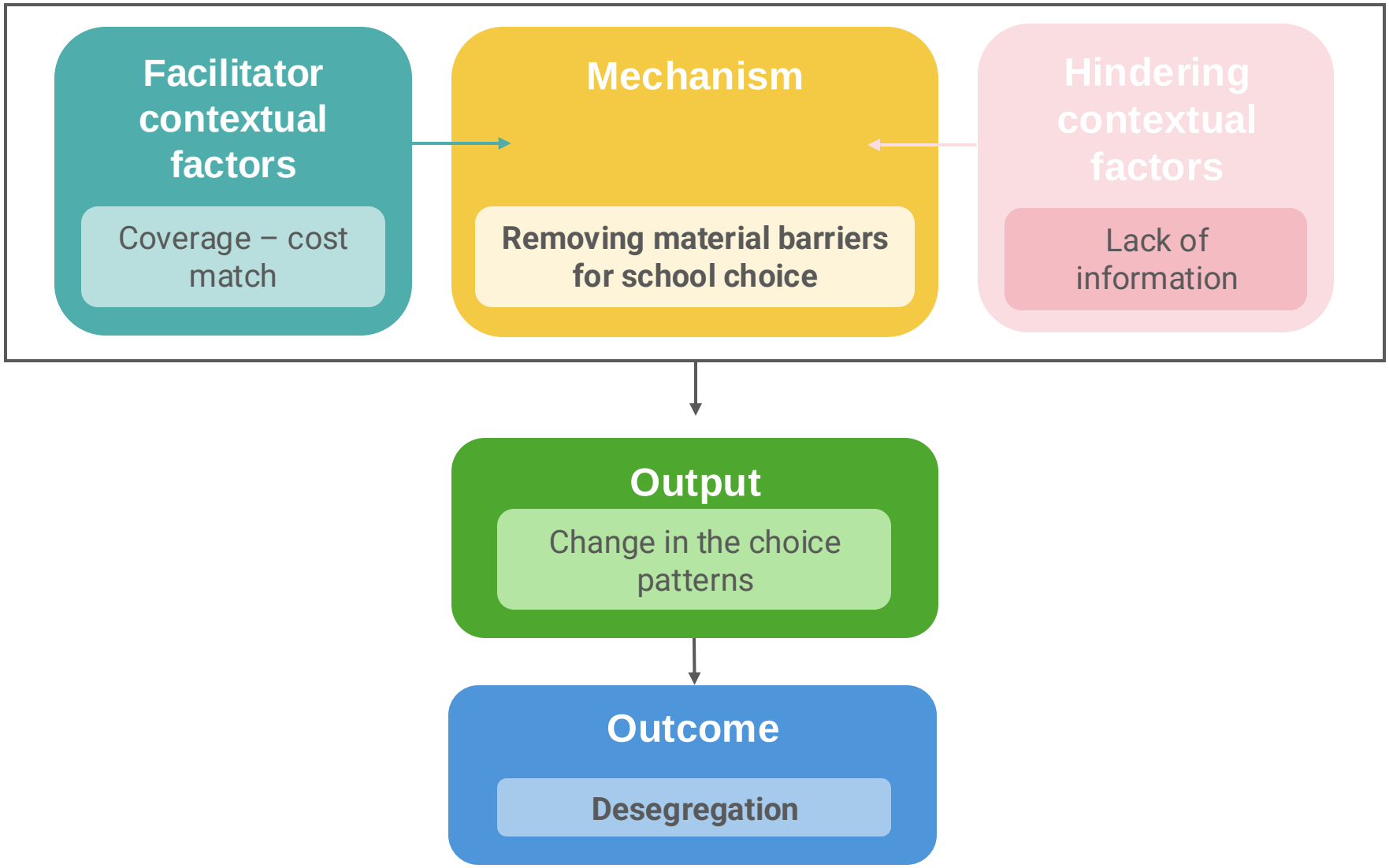

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Mechanisms: exemple

Facilitator contextual factors

Coverage – cost match

Q: And how do you change from a public school to a publicly founded private school?

A: **This is thanks to the SPAS. If it wasn't for the SPAS it would be very expensive**. I couldn't pay it, it's very expensive, and this is an opportunity, I appreciate it very much. (Family 9)

Output

Change in the choice patterns

Outcome

Desegregation

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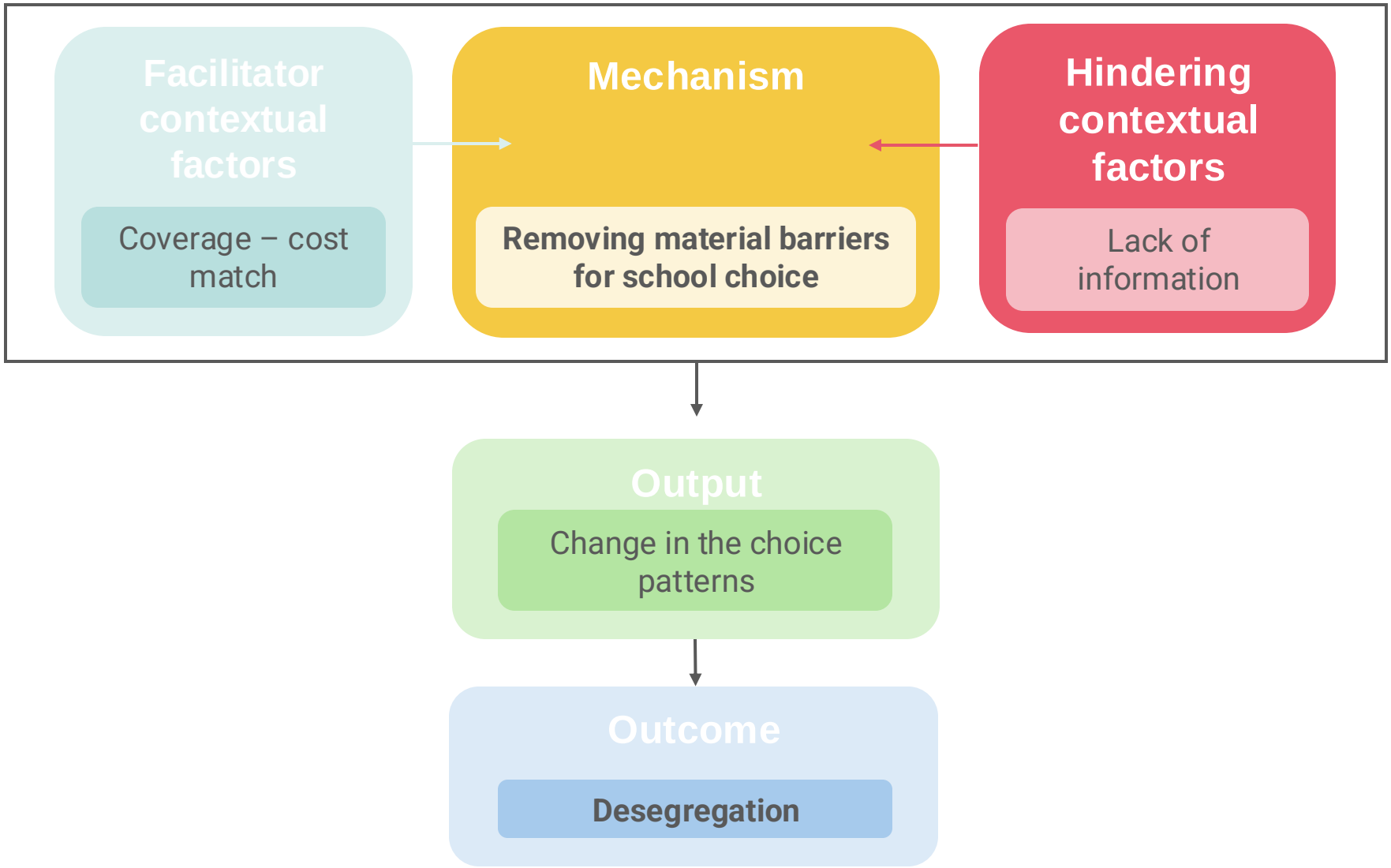
Mechanisms: exemple



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Mechanisms: exemple

- *Q: Do you plan to change the school considering the cost coverage?*
- A: I don't know, **I'm scared that they're going to take away the coverage if he changes**, I don't know... I don't know if in another school they're going to put him out of the program (...) **none has told me that, is just that I feel he will lose the aid if he change the school** (Family 56)

Hindering contextual factors

Lack of information

Output

Change in the choice patterns

Outcome

Desegregation

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Preliminary conclusions

- **The SP is a limited instrument to reduce school segregation:**
  1. Its design is not sensitive to contextual conditions (and they have clear effects)
  2. The theory of change is not reached (beyond material factors: the symbolic effects).

- **Next steps:**
  1. A complete analysis of the other instruments will provide more complex and holistic understanding of the working mechanisms of desegregation policies
  2. Unexpected results:
     - Increasing the concentration of vulnerable students in specific areas / schools
     - Mitigation of material deprivation